

Session 22: Noah's Ark and the Flood Debate

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors used cosmic hyperbole to emphasize the all-encompassing importance of the events described.
- Key vocabulary from the flood account is used at other points in the Bible to emphasize God's cosmic authority to hand creation over to its own self-destruction.

A Global Flood, a Local Flood, or Cosmic Collapse?

These two interpretive positions have received the most airtime in popular debate and culture. What they have in common is a desire to match the narrative details of the flood (especially Gen. 7:11-24) to a reconstructible historical flood that can be dated and located.

Both of these positions assume that the biblical author shares our modern cosmology and conception of the world as a "globe." Based on this assumption, the interpretive question becomes: Did the author have knowledge of the scope of the flood? This question results in multiple views.

- Global flood: The author knew (by divine inspiration) that the flood immersed the entire globe and depicted it as such.
- Local flood: The author didn't know about the scope and size of the globe and so depicted a localized flood as if it encompassed the entire globe.

Underneath this entire debate is an unexamined problem. The biblical authors did not share our modern cosmology, and the word "land" does not mean globe.

The language of 7:11-12 makes it clear that the author is working with an ancient world picture of a three-tiered cosmos.

Genesis 7:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ And in the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on that day all **the fountains of the great deep burst open**, and **the windows of the skies were opened**.¹² And there was rain upon the land for forty days and forty nights.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These phrases refer to the author's ancient conception of the waters above and below, which were separated on day two of Genesis. These cosmic waters exist and are held at bay only by Yahweh's covenant promise.

Genesis 1:6-8 NASB*

⁶ Then God said, "Let there be an dome in the midst of the waters, and let it separate **the waters** from the **waters**." ⁷ God made the dome, and separated **the waters which were below the dome** from **the waters which were above the dome** and it was so. ⁸ God called the dome heavens/ skies. And there was evening and there was morning, a second day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 148:1-6 NASB

- ¹ Praise the LORD! Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!
² Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!
³ Praise him, sun and moon; praise him, all stars of light!
⁴ Praise him, **highest heavens, and the waters that are above the heavens**!
⁵ Let them praise the name of the LORD, for he commanded and they were created.
⁶ He has also **established them forever and ever; he has made a decree which will not pass away.**

Psalm 24:1-2 NASB*

- ¹ The **land** is the LORD's, and all it contains, the **world**, and those who dwell in it.
² For **he has founded it upon the seas, and established it upon the rivers.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 136:5-6 NASB

- ⁵ [Give thanks] to him who made the heavens with skill, for his lovingkindness is everlasting;
⁶ to **him who spread out the land above the waters**, for his lovingkindness is everlasting ...

Psalm 104:5 NASB*

He established the land upon its foundations, so that it will not totter forever and ever.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In light of the biblical authors' ancient cosmology, the depiction of the flood is neither global nor local. It is cosmic, or, more specifically, the flood is a cosmic collapse, a de-creation narrative. In other words, the depiction of the flood is an attempt to show its cosmic meaning and significance within the divine purpose.

Cosmic Hyperbole and the Flood Design Pattern in the Hebrew Bible

The author gives many clear signals that the flood has cosmic significance and affects the entire created realm. The following list is adapted from *The Lost World of the Flood* by Longman and Walton (2018, 48-49).

- God's perception of humanity in Genesis 6:5-13 includes all humanity, not just those in a local area.
- The flood is clearly portrayed as a reversal of the cosmic order that God established in Genesis 1 and then a re-creation similar to Genesis 1. For the analogy to work, the flood is a cosmic re-creation and not simply a local phenomenon.
- The collapse of the waters above and below in Genesis 7:11 indicates a cosmic event.

- The logic of taking animals on board in pairs, including birds, indicates a cosmic flood not limited to a local area.
- The size of the boat indicates a flood of cosmic proportions.
- The height of the waters as 15 cubits (23 feet) above the mountains of Ararat (Gen. 7:20, 8:4) indicates a cosmic flood.

The author's purpose is to depict a catastrophe of cosmic proportions, which raises an even deeper question. Do the biblical authors ever use cosmic hyperbole (intentional literary exaggeration) to communicate the cosmic importance and significance of an event but not necessarily its actual universal scope?

The answer is yes. Biblical authors regularly use hyperbole to communicate the cosmic meaning of an event. In fact, the flood narrative begins an important design pattern about God's cosmic judgment against humanity's evil, and we often find the same hyperbole at work.

Cosmic Hyperbole in the Ten Plagues on Egypt

Exodus 7:20-25 NASB

²⁰ So Moses and Aaron did even as the LORD had commanded. And he lifted up the staff and struck the water that was in the Nile, in the sight of Pharaoh and in the sight of his servants, and **all the water that was in the Nile was turned to blood.** ²¹ The fish that were in the Nile died, and the Nile became foul, so that the Egyptians could not drink water from the Nile. And the **blood was through all the land of Egypt** ... ²⁴ So all the Egyptians **dug around the Nile for water** to drink, for they could not drink of the water of the Nile. ²⁵ Seven days passed after the LORD had struck the Nile.

Exodus 8:17 NASB

They did so; and Aaron stretched out his hand with his staff, and struck the dust of the earth, and there were gnats on man and beast. **All the dust of the earth became gnats** through all the land of Egypt.

Exodus 9:3-6 NASB

³ Behold, the hand of the LORD will come with a very severe pestilence on your livestock which are in the field, on the horses, on the donkeys, on the camels, on the herds, and on the flocks. ⁴ But the LORD will make a distinction between the livestock of Israel and the livestock of Egypt, so that nothing will die of all that belongs to the sons of Israel ... ⁶ So the LORD did this thing on the next day, and **all the livestock of Egypt died**; but of the livestock of the sons of Israel, not one died.

Exodus 9:22-25 NASB

²² Now the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward the sky, that hail may fall on all the land of Egypt, **on man and on beast and on every plant of the field, throughout the land of Egypt.**" ²³ Moses stretched out his staff toward the sky, and the LORD sent thunder and hail, and fire ran down to the earth. And the LORD rained hail on the land of Egypt. ... ²⁵ The hail struck **all that was in the field through all the land of Egypt**, both man and beast; the hail also struck **every plant of the field** and shattered **every tree of the field.**

Exodus 9:31-32 NASB

³¹ Now the flax and the barley were ruined, for the barley was in the ear and the flax was in bud. ³² But the wheat and the spelt were not ruined, for they ripen late.

Exodus 10:21-23 NASB

²¹ Then the LORD said to Moses, "Stretch out your hand toward the sky, that there may be darkness over the land of Egypt, even a darkness which may be felt." ²² So Moses stretched out his hand toward the sky, and there was **thick darkness in all the land of Egypt** for three days. ²³ They did not see one another, nor did anyone rise from his place for three days, but all the sons of Israel had light in their dwellings.

Notice how the leading statements about the plague are cosmic in scope ("all the water," "all the plants"), but they are followed by a qualification that all doesn't technically mean all: There is still water to drink and there are plants that survived the hail.

Cosmic Hyperbole in the Conquest of the Canaanites

Joshua 10:40-42 NASB

⁴⁰ Thus Joshua struck **all the land**, the hill country and the Negev and the lowland and the slopes and **all their kings**. He left **no survivor**, but he utterly destroyed **all who breathed**, just as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded. ⁴¹ Joshua struck them from Kadesh-barnea even as far as Gaza, and all the country of Goshen even as far as Gibeon. ⁴² Joshua captured **all these kings** and their lands **at one time**, because the LORD, the God of Israel, fought for Israel.

Joshua 11:16-17 NASB

¹⁶ Thus Joshua took **all that land**: the hill country and all the Negev, **all that land** of Goshen, the lowland, the Arabah, the hill country of Israel and its lowland ¹⁷ from Mount Halak, that rises toward Seir, even as far as Baal-gad in the valley of Lebanon at the foot of Mount Hermon. And he captured **all their kings** and struck them down and put them to death.

Joshua 11:23 NASB

So Joshua took **all the land**, according to all that the LORD had spoken to Moses, and Joshua gave it for an inheritance to Israel according to their divisions by their tribes. Thus the land had rest from war.

From these summary statements, the reader naturally concludes that the entire land of Canaan was now in Israel's possession and that all hostile kings had been eliminated. But notice the opening sentences of the very next chapter.

Joshua 13:1-5 NASB

¹ Now Joshua was old and advanced in years when Yahweh said to him, "You are old and advanced in years, **and very much of the land remains to be possessed**." ² This is **the land that remains**: all the regions of the Philistines and all those of the Geshurites; ³ from the Shihor which is east of Egypt, even as far as the border of Ekron to the north (it is counted as Canaanite); the five lords of the Philistines: the Gazite, the Ashdodite,

the Ashkelonite, the Gittite, the Ekronite; and the Avvite ⁴ to the south, all the land of the Canaanite, and Mearah that belongs to the Sidonians, as far as Aphek, to the border of the Amorite; ⁵ and the land of the Gebalite, and all of Lebanon, toward the east, from Baal-gad below Mount Hermon as far as Lebo-hamath.”

“A Bible atlas will show visually that this description encompasses quite a bit of land. Indeed a rough estimate would place the success level at around 50 percent ... In addition, there were some important cities said to be taken by Israel that remained firmly in the hands of Canaanites, most notably Jerusalem and Hebron (see [Josh. 12:10](#)). According to Judges chapter 1, the situation did not change dramatically even after the death of Joshua ([Judg. 1:1](#)), where we hear that Israel had not defeated large swaths of Canaanite territory ... The author is intentionally using universalistic language and intends to convey rhetorically that the conquest was complete. However, this completeness did not correspond to the actual geographical scope of the conquest, but to the significance of the conquest. The use of hyperbole serves to make the theological point ... We recognize that some will have difficulty with the presence of hyperbole in Scripture, even if it is obvious as we have seen in Joshua. Our point is that the biblical authors sometimes use hyperbole ... in a way that they expected their readers to recognize ... as a convention for making theological claims.”

Longman, T. and Walton, J. H. (2018). [The Lost World of the Flood: Mythology, Theology, and the Deluge Debate](#)." IVP Academic. 32-33.

Also, there are cities that are said to have been captured by the Israelites, but later on in the story we find these cities in Canaanite possession.

Narratives of Cities Conquered	Later Narrative Where the Same Cities Are Not Conquered
Joshua 8:17–19 ¹⁷ So not a man was left in Ai or Bethel who had not gone out after Israel, and they left the city unguarded and pursued Israel. ¹⁸ Then the Lord said to Joshua, “Stretch out the javelin that is in your hand toward Ai, for I will give it into your hand.” So Joshua stretched out the javelin that was in his hand toward the city. ¹⁹ The men in ambush rose quickly from their place, and when he had stretched out his hand, they ran and entered the city and captured it, and they quickly set the city on fire. Joshua 12:7, 16 ⁷ Here is a list of the kings of the land that Joshua and the Israelites conquered on the west side of	Judges 1:22–25 ²² Likewise the house of Joseph went up against Bethel, and the LORD was with them. ²³ The house of Joseph spied out Bethel (now the name of the city was formerly Luz). ²⁴ The spies saw a man coming out of the city and they said to him, “Please show us the entrance to the city and we will treat you kindly.” ²⁵ So he showed them the entrance to the city, and they struck the city with the edge of the sword, but they let the man and all his family go free.
<i>Conquest Narrative Cities Before and After.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Narratives of Cities Conquered	Later Narrative Where the Same Cities Are Not Conquered
the Jordan... ¹⁶ the king of Bethel	
Joshua 10:36–39 ³⁶ Then Joshua and all Israel with him went up from Eglon to Hebron, and they fought against it. ³⁷ They captured it and struck it and its king and all its cities and all the persons who were in it with the edge of the sword. He left no survivor, according to all that he had done to Eglon. And he utterly destroyed it and every person who was in it. ³⁸ Then Joshua and all Israel with him returned to Debir, and they fought against it. ³⁹ He captured it and its king and all its cities, and they struck them with the edge of the sword, and utterly destroyed every person who was in it. He left no survivor. Just as he had done to Hebron, so he did to Debir and its king, as he had also done to Libnah and its king.	Joshua 15:13–17 ¹³ Now he gave to Caleb the son of Jephunneh a portion among the sons of Judah, according to the command of the LORD to Joshua, namely, Kiriath-arba, Arba being the father of Anak (that is, Hebron). ¹⁴ Caleb drove out from there the three sons of Anak: Sheshai and Ahiman and Talmai, the children of Anak. ¹⁵ Then he went up from there against the inhabitants of Debir; now the name of Debir formerly was Kiriath-sepher. ¹⁶ And Caleb said, “The one who attacks Kiriath-sepher and captures it, I will give him Achsah my daughter as a wife.” ¹⁷ Othniel the son of Kenaz, the brother of Caleb, captured it; so he gave him Achsah his daughter as a wife.
<i>Conquest Narrative Cities Before and After.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

In both cases, Bethel, Hebron, and Debir appear in summarizing lists where cities are conquered in a formulaic fashion. But when we come across these same cities later in the narrative, they have not been conquered, and they are filled with Canaanite inhabitants.

Let’s go back to the flood narrative. We noted that the entire flood story from Genesis 6:1-9:27 is a cohesive literary whole that has been placed in between the genealogies of Genesis 5 and 10. If we look before and after the flood narrative, we find pre-flood characters who are still present after the flood.

Pre-Flood Characters	Same Characters After the Flood
The Nephilim in Genesis 6:4 The Nephilim were in the land in those days—and also afterward—when the sons of God went to the daughters of humans and had children by them. These were the heroes of old, men of renown.	Numbers 13:31–33 ³¹ But the men who had gone up with him said, “We can’t attack those people; they are stronger than we are.” ³² And they spread among the Israelites a bad report about the land they had explored. They said, “The land we explored devours those living in it. All the people we saw there are of great size. ³³ We saw the Nephilim there (the descendants of Anak come from the Nephilim). We seemed like grasshoppers in our own eyes, and we looked the same to them.”
The line of Cain Genesis 4:17, 19-21 ¹⁷ Cain had relations with his wife and she conceived, and gave birth to Enoch; and he built a city, and called the name of the city Enoch, after the name of his son. ¹⁹ Lemek married two women, one named Adah and the other Zillah. ²⁰ Adah gave birth to Jabal; the father of those who live in tents and raise livestock. ²¹ His brother’s name was Jubal; he was the father of all who play stringed instruments and pipes.	Genesis 15:18–19 ¹⁸ On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram and said, “To your descendants I give this land, from the Wadi of Egypt to the great river, the Euphrates— ¹⁹ the land of the Cainites, Kenizzites, Kadmonites, Numbers 24:21–22 ²¹ Then [Balaam] saw the Cainites and spoke his message: “Your dwelling place is secure, your nest is set in a rock; ²² yet you Cainites will be destroyed when Ashur takes you captive.” Judges 4:11 ¹¹ Now Heber the Cainite had separated himself from the Cainites, from the sons of Hobab the father-in-law of Moses, and had pitched his tent as far away as the oak in Zaanannim, which is near Kedesh.
<i>Characters Before and After the Flood.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Cosmic Hyperbole and the Theological Message of the Biblical Flood Story

The flood narrative seems to be a cosmic portrayal of a real flood that took place in ancient Mesopotamia. The cosmic hyperbole of the biblical account is part of its theological design and communication strategy.

The biblical authors are not deceptive. They intentionally provide a stylized and creative presentation of the flood narrative in order to make theological claims.

The Historicity of the Flood Narrative

We have substantial reason to think that the flood narrative is rooted in ancient Mesopotamian tradition and originates from a real, catastrophic flood during the prehistoric period (namely, before the advent of history writing during the early empires of Sumer and Akkad).

All the flood accounts from Mesopotamia clearly belong to the same general family of traditions that go back beyond the year 2,000 B.C.E. Also, Mesopotamia is a huge flood plain where two large regional rivers merge together.

There is also evidence of occasional catastrophic floods. In the work of William Ryan and Walter Pitman (*Noah's Flood: The New Scientific Discoveries About an Event That Changed History*, 2000), they describe a flood that would date to around 5,600 B.C.E. that explains the geological shape of the divide between eastern Europe and Anatolia (modern day Turkey) and the origins of the Black Sea.

We can clearly see that the biblical flood narrative has been adopted from a Mesopotamian tradition of the flood story and adapted for the theological purposes of the authors.

Reflection Question

What is the significance of the biblical authors' use of flood language in other stories later in the Bible?